



the majority of Bengalis in Bangladesh are Muslims, while most of those in West Bengal are Hindus. Some reside in densely populated cities such as Calcutta in India and Dhaka in Bangladesh, but millions more live

in rural areas. Bengali fishermen and farmers rely on the annual flooding of the Ganges and Brahmaputra rivers for their livelihoods. Often though, these very same floods cause devastation and huge loss of life.

### BRITISH LEGACY



During the 18th and 19th centuries, the British Raj (colonial rulers) built grand, European-style buildings in Calcutta. These include an imposing memorial to Queen Victoria and the gothic St. Paul's cathedral.

### Farming in Bangladesh

Over 60 percent of Bangladeshis work in agriculture growing rice, jute, tea, and wheat as their main crops. Many live on and cultivate land that is prone to flooding—they have little choice when about a third of the country floods regularly during the monsoon season. The climate coupled with widespread poverty has resulted in numerous environmental problems.

Women extract the golden fibers from jute plants that have been left to soak.

### AN IMPORTANT CROP

Jute, which is used to make sacks and carpet backing, is Bangladesh's biggest export. About 25 million people, almost a quarter of the population, make a living from growing or processing the crop.



#### 1 Harvesting

Jute grows in hot, humid conditions. Plants are harvested when they are 8-12 ft (2.5-3.5 m) tall. The stalks are bundled up and soaked so the fiber can be extracted.



#### 2 Processing

The fibers are passed through a series of machines to soften them and remove any bits of bark. Eventually they are turned into a strong yarn.



#### 3 The end result

Jute fabric has a variety of uses. It is known as burlap, sack, or canvas, depending on how fine or coarse it is.

